

PSYCH NOTES · WEEK 1

FREUD'S PSYCHOANALYSIS

Id · Ego · Superego + 8 Defense Mechanisms

Everything you need to know in 60 seconds

"This confused me too... until I made this."





The Mind Is an Iceberg

Conscious = what you notice right now (the tip). Preconscious = memories you can pull up when needed (just below the waterline). Unconscious = wishes, fears and memories pushed out of awareness — the biggest part, still steering your behaviour.

KEY TERM Unconscious



Fun fact: Freud never used the iceberg image himself — it came later via G. Stanley Hall (Green, 2019). The three levels are Freud's: the topographic model.



Id, Ego, Superego: The Trio

Id: "I want it NOW" — pleasure principle, present from birth. Superego: "You SHOULD" — morality principle, learned from parents and society. Ego: the referee — reality principle, finds a realistic way to satisfy the Id without angering the Superego.

**ID**

Pleasure principle

"I want it NOW."

wants

**EGO**

Reality principle

"Let's find a way."

demands

**SUPEREGO**

Morality principle

*"You SHOULD."***KEY TERMS** pleasure principle · reality principle · morality principle

Born with the Id; the Ego develops as a child meets reality; the Superego forms as rules are internalised (roughly ages 3–6).



Exam Night: The Trio Fights

ID

"Ek episode aur... phone uthao."

SUPREGO

"Padhoge nahi toh Papa ka bharosa tootega."

EGO

"Deal: 20 min break, 2 ghante revision, 11:30 so."



Exam kal hai. Teeno bolte hain — aur a strong Ego negotiates. When it can't, the clash creates anxiety.

KEY TERM anxiety → triggers the Ego's defenses (next slide)



Defense Mechanisms: The Ego's Shields

When Id-Superego conflict creates anxiety, the Ego protects itself automatically and unconsciously — with defense mechanisms (mapped in detail by Anna Freud, 1936). Everyone uses them. Trouble starts only when one becomes your default.

PUSH IT DOWN

Repression

Painful memory pushed out of awareness.
"Bachpan ki woh baat... yaad hi nahi."

Denial

Refusing to see what's real. "Mujhe koi stress nahi hai" (result 'kal, nails chewed).

PUSH IT OUT

Projection

Your feeling, pinned on someone else. "Main nahi — WOH jealous hai."

Displacement

Feeling redirected to a safer target. Boss ne daanta → chhote bhai pe gussa.





Four More Shields

DRESS IT UP

Rationalisation

A logical-sounding excuse for the real reason.
"Woh company waise bhi achhi nahi thi."

Reaction formation

Acting the opposite of what you feel. Secretly like someone → extra rude to them.

GO BACK / GO UP

Regression

Sliding back to a younger self under stress.
Breakup → Mummy ke haath ka khaana aur sulking.

Sublimation

Channelling the urge into something useful.
Gussa → gym, cricket, poetry. The healthiest one.

Freud today: many of his specifics can't be tested (Popper, 1963), but defense mechanisms are still researched and ranked from immature to mature (Vaillant, 2000; Cramer, 2015).





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Sources: Freud, S. (1923/1961). The ego and the id. SE 19 · Freud, A. (1936/1937). The ego and the mechanisms of defence · NCERT (2007). Psychology, Class XII, Ch. 2 · Vaillant, G. E. (2000). Am Psychol, 55(1) · Cramer, P. (2015). Psychodyn Psychiatry, 43(4) · Green, C. D. (2019). Hist Psychol, 22(4)

